

ASSESSING YOUR SITE AND SOIL

It is important to discover as much as possible about the conditions that prevail in your garden before you start planning and planting. Take note of the local environment and climate, as well as the topography

and soil conditions, as your plant choices will be determined by these factors. Check the aspect, which influences the sun and shade in a garden, and the soil type, to discover its moisture and nutrient content.

Understanding aspect

Determining how much sun and shade your garden receives is of paramount importance when making plant selections. Some plants prefer full sun, for example, while others need partial or full shade to thrive. You can use a compass to figure out which way areas or borders face. Those facing south will be in sun for most of the day, while those that face north will be shady. East-facing areas have morning sun and evening shade, while the opposite applies to those facing west.

Patterns of sun and shade also change throughout the day, and a garden that is in full sun at midday may have areas of shade in the morning and late afternoon. For this reason, it is wise to study your garden on a sunny day and make a note of the way shadows move around the plot. Remember, too, that the seasons can affect the level of sunlight in a garden; for example, an area that is in sun in the summer could be in constant shade during the winter, which may have an effect on evergreens that need a sunny site to thrive.

However much sun your garden receives, there are plenty of plants to choose from that will thrive in those conditions. As well as plants for sun or shade, there are many that are happy with a little of both.



Assessing microclimates

Variations in the conditions in different parts of a garden are described as “microclimates,” and may include frost pockets at the bottom of a slope, sheltered hot spots by a warm wall, pockets of wind turbulence, and exposed sites. Rather than limit your plant choice, microclimates actually allow you to grow a wider range of plants, so note the temperature, water levels, and air and wind circulation around your garden.

ABOVE Plants that thrive in sun

Alliums, with their dramatic globes of rich pinkish-purple flowers, thrive in open, sunny sites, and make great partners for other sun-lovers, like catmints and salvias.

Types of soil

Knowing your soil type is key to growing healthy plants. It is always preferable to select those that thrive in the soil you have, rather than fighting it by trying to grow plants that are not adapted to your conditions, as they will inevitably suffer.

There are three main types of soil: sand, clay, and silt. They are categorized according to the size of the soil particles, which determines the level of water and plant food they can hold. Most garden soils are a combination of sand and clay, with one type dominating the mix; the ideal soil is “loam,” which contains almost equal measures of sand and clay.

Sandy soils Sandy soil particles are relatively large and water drains freely through the spaces between them. As a result, these soils are free-draining, but because plant nutrients are dissolved in water, they are also quite infertile. Sandy soil is ideal for Mediterranean plants.

Clay soils Clay particles are minute, and trap moisture in the gaps between them.

LEFT Growing shade-lovers

Shade-loving plants, such as the hart's tongue fern (*Asplenium scolopendrium*), flourish under the light shade provided by silver birch trees (*Betula pendula*).

